



Palais Garnier

Location Paris, France

The Palais Garnier is the home of the Paris Opéra, a ballet and opera company, and the building itself is often simply called the Opéra. Designed by Charles Garnier, it opened in 1875. It was both the most feted and the most controversial structure in the rebuilding of Paris initiated by Napoleon III (r.1852–1870). It was criticized as a vanity project on the part of the emperor, and for its immense cost. The mixing of Renaissance, Baroque, and Rococo styles and lavish decoration led many to brand it merely vulgar. Nevertheless, its almost heroic self-assertion—expressed most obviously in its huge, marbled foyer, dominated by a giant staircase that branches in two—is a potent assertion of Belle Epoque opulence.

Galleria Vittorio Emanuele II

Location Milan, Italy

Giuseppe Mengoni's towering Galleria Vittorio Emanuele II, built between 1865 and 1877, was always

▲ THE PALAIS GARNIER'S AUDITORIUM, RICHLY DECORATED IN RED AND GOLD

meant to be more than a vast covered public space. Its goal was to showcase a new, technologically potent Italy after the country's unification in 1861, while paying homage to the country's past. Its iron-and-glass tunnel-vaulted roofs and octagonal glass dome are clear indications of Italy's industrial prowess and presumed future. Simultaneously, its cross-shaped floor plan recalls its Christian past. No less symbolically, the longest arms run from the Piazza della Scala opera house to the Piazza del Duomo museum, reinforcing the link between the country's artistic and religious heritage. The architecture of the body of the structure is impressively, if ponderously, Classical.

Cardiff Castle

Location Cardiff, Wales

Constructed on Roman foundations, Cardiff Castle is a Norman building that, between 1868 and 1885, was wholly transformed by the most imaginative English Victorian Gothic revivalist, William Burgess. Burgess was employed by the

enormously rich Marquess of Bute, whose great delight in the medieval world matched that of his architect. They proved a formidable pairing. The chief joy of Cardiff Castle lies in its intricate and astonishingly rich interiors, most of them vast—the banquet hall and library in particular. The Arab room is a no less astounding expression of brilliantly vivid medieval fantasy, its ceiling a dizzy, overlapping maze of Moorish arches climbing upward. Imposing stone fireplaces, brilliantly colored, abound. Almost everywhere, there are sudden touches of precisely crafted whimsy.

Palácio da Pena

Location Sintra, Portugal

Progressively remodeled between 1842 and 1885 as a summer retreat for Portugal's royal family by the German architect Baron Ludwig von Eschwege, Palácio de Pena ranks high among the world's most unlikely buildings. Built on the remains of a late 15th-century monastery, it rises, domed, turreted, and castellated, on a steeply wooded crag over the

► THE BRIGHTLY COLORED EXTERIOR OF PALÁCIO DA PENA

elegant town of Sintra. It is part Rhineland castle, part Moorish stronghold, and part mere fantasy belonging to no obvious architectural type. The building's asymmetrical, blocky elements are vividly rendered in ochers, purples, and deep reds. Few buildings are more improbable or possess so clear a sense of romantic unreality. Its rich, dusky interiors conjure a feeling of equal astonishment.

Rijksmuseum

Location Amsterdam, the Netherlands

One of the world's great galleries, the Rijksmuseum is home to about a million objects from every artistic field. Designed by Dutch architect Pierre Cuypers, it was built in 1876–1885. With its turrets and towers, gables and dormers, and boldly projecting masses with stone banding and molding over its deep-red bricks, it might almost be a hybrid late-Gothic-early-Renaissance Loire château. It has two main facades. The central bays of that facing the Singelgracht canal are animated by large, round-headed traceried windows. The opposite facade features a no less imposing entrance arch. The interior is organized around two substantial, glassed courtyards. From 2004 to 2012, the museum underwent a

